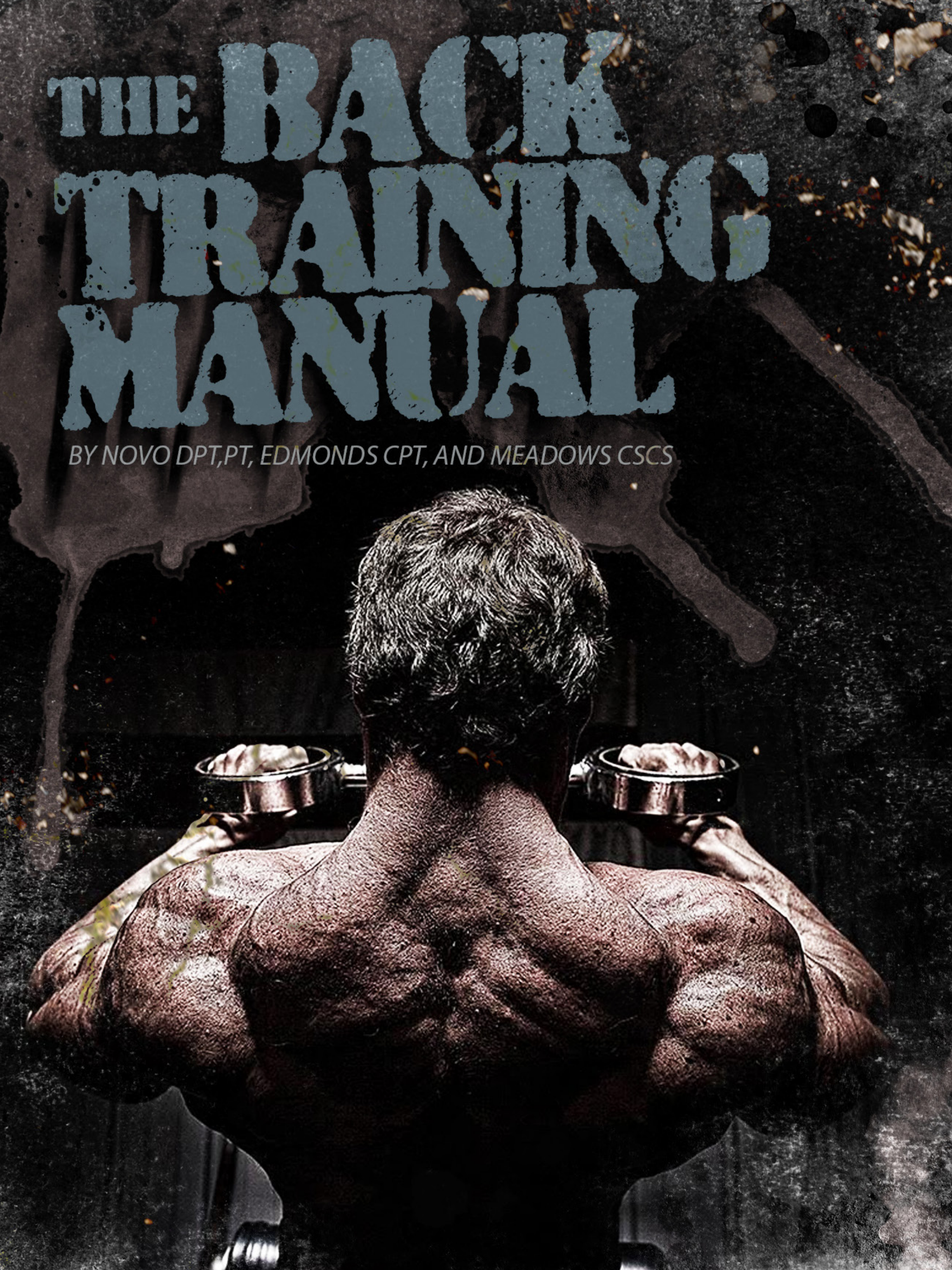
THE BACK TRAINING MANUAL

BY NOVO DPT,PT, EDMONDS CPT, AND MEADOWS CSCS



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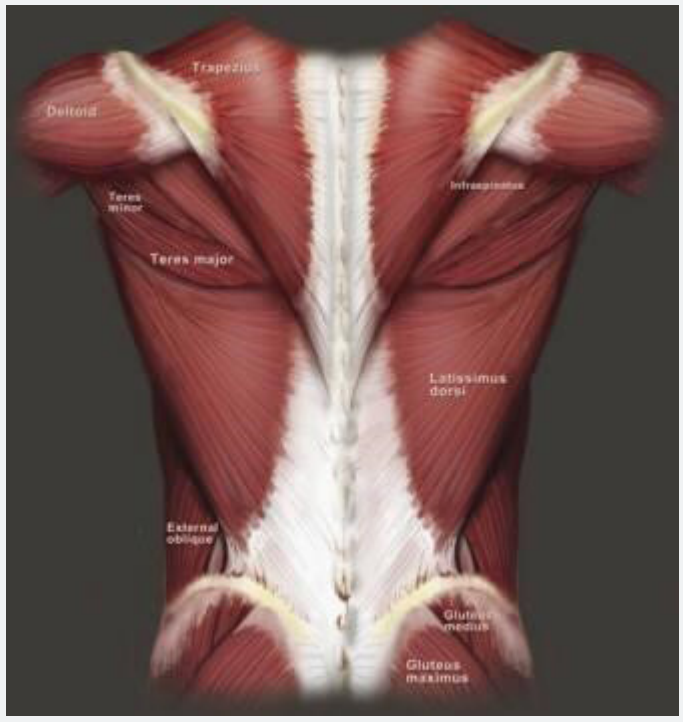
INTRODUCTION

Good day everyone and thank you so much for purchasing our back-training e-book. This is the 2nd in our series in which we will cover all major body parts! If you missed the arm training manual, make sure you check it out!

It's always good to have an understanding of anatomy and how musculature works so we are going to start this e-book with that, and then progress into the actual 6-week program you will be doing. You will learn what to do, and why you are doing it!

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN:

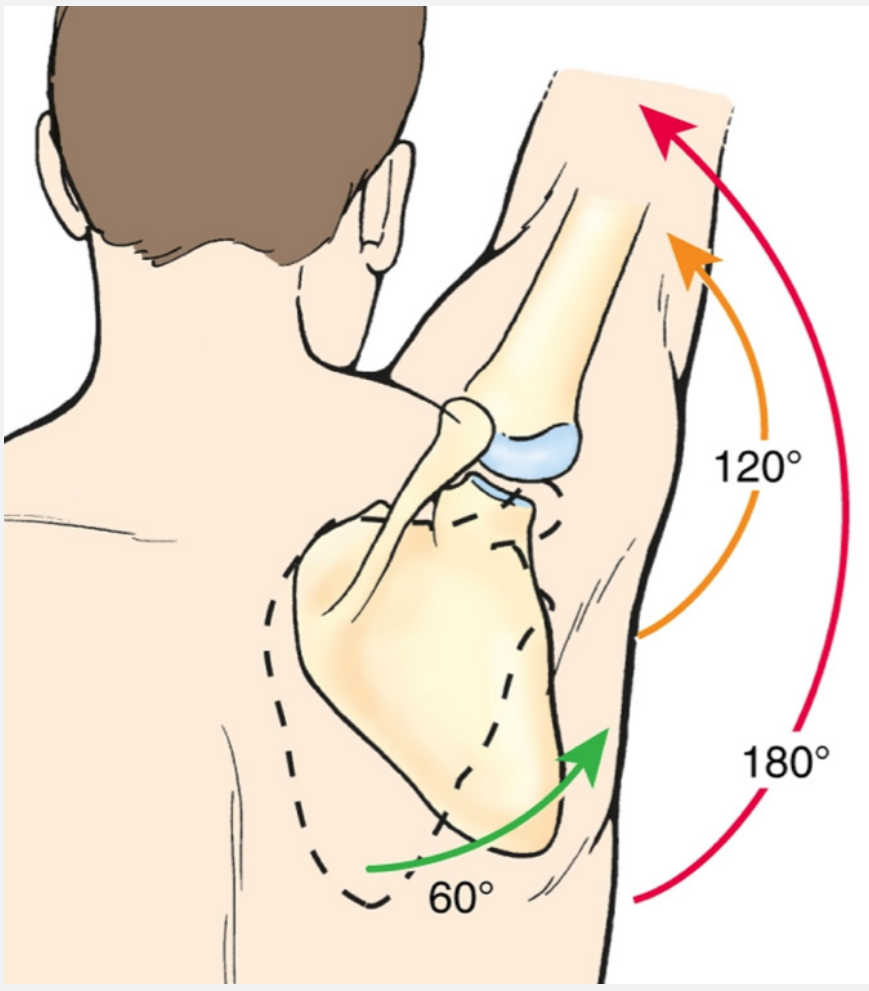
For anybody new to Mountain Dog Training, get ready to grow your back! If you have white man's disease (small back) do not be discouraged. We are not all genetically gifted, it took me years of doing the same routine, while hiding my back at shows; before I made the leap in my physique by training smarter. The time spent in the gym should be an investment through every rep, and set towards achieving success through intensity, intelligent techniques, and hard facts.



If there was one body part that spoke volumes about training experience and success it would be the traps. Starting from the top down, the traps are divided into 3 regions known as the upper, middle, and lower trapezius. The primary function of this muscle group, aside from providing that "jacked" looked, is to influence shoulder blade elevation, upward/downward rotation and retraction (otherwise known as squeezing the shoulder blades together). Each of these functions all play a critical role in providing stability for your shoulder.

You see, the shoulder, known as the glenohumeral joint is a ball and socket configuration wherein both the socket and the ball move dependent to one another. This unique movement is known as the scapula-humeral rhythm; wherein for every two degrees of arm movement on the socket, the shoulder blade moves 1 degree. Hence, a 2 to 1 ratio (2:1). If not for this rhythmic movement, you would never be able to perform a vertical shoulder press; and in many cases is the reason why people have shoulder pain with pressing in the first place.

To further break down this point let's just apply some math to help the light bulb go off; that or just use the image provided.



The arm or true shoulder joint (glenohumeral J) only has a permissible 120° of movement before it becomes jammed up against the bony outcrop of the shoulder blade known as the acromion. If the shoulder blade was fixed to the spine, much like pelvis and hip joint are (Another ball and socket joint), there would be no absolute way for us to reach vertically upward (180°).

Insert the 2:1 ratio of arm to shoulder blade and voila! 120°:60°!

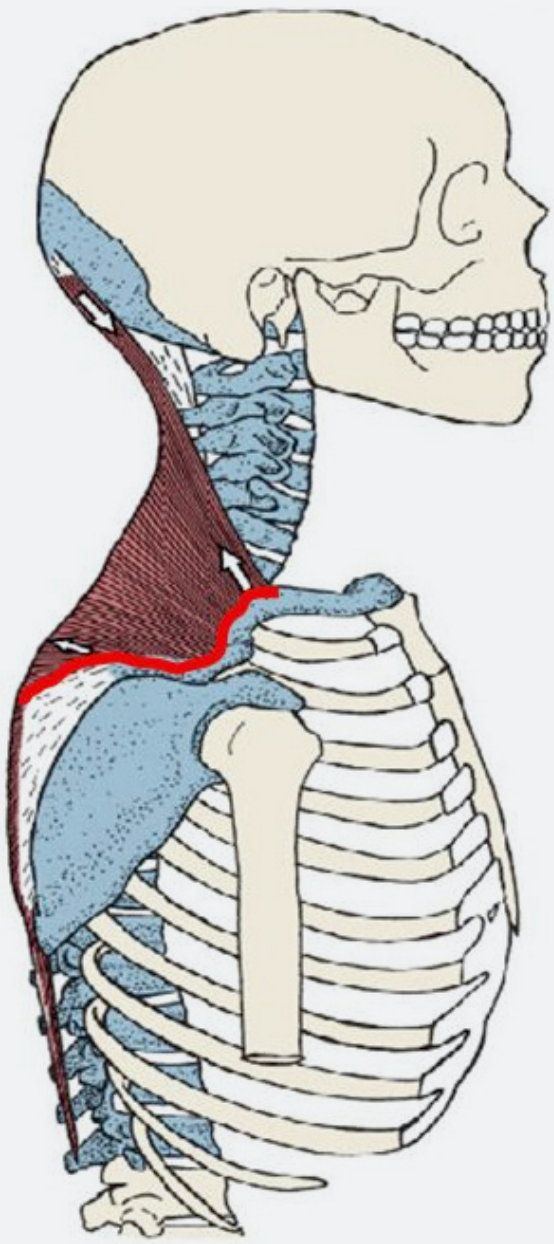
Now add 60° to the maxed out 120°, and we achieve our 180° shoulder elevation.

Understanding that the arm is truly reliant on the shoulder blade to be both a mobile and stable foundation is much like "firing a cannon from a canoe". That last quote was compliments of a good friend of mine who is an orthopedic surgeon.

What we need to take away from that last example is that the traps are important; and not just for aesthetics but more so for their unique ability to generate the stability needed for your arm to press, pull, and ultimately grow from.

I rarely do traps anymore because they became quite dominant eventually, but the techniques and exercises I used, I believe are very powerful. Luckily, I didn't forget it all! Let's discuss each section in more detail.

UPPER TRAP



The upper fibers of the trap originate near the back of the skull (occiput) and along the seventh cervical vertebra; with an insertion along the lateral third of the collarbone (Johnson et al. 2005). This specific anatomical insertion allows the upper trap to focus its greatest intent on stabilizing the shoulder blade to produce neck extension and the contrast, where the cervical spine must become the stable foundation for shoulder lateral abduction or pressing to occur (Ackland et al. 2011). Hence, it is not uncommon for people to feel their traps when performing lateral arm raises, as they may not yet understand how to dissociate their traps from their delts. This is in fact, a very tough thing to do for many, as their traps can easily takeover on a side lateral.

Upper trap evidence promotes the inclusion of weighted farmers walks, suitcase carries and or any weighted carries; as peak upper trap recruitment can be seen during these activities. Equally, activities that involve scapular elevation which can be seen during shrugs, deadlifts, bent over rows, and even upright rows (although prior shoulder health should be considered when performing the upright row to avoid shoulder impingement at all cost).

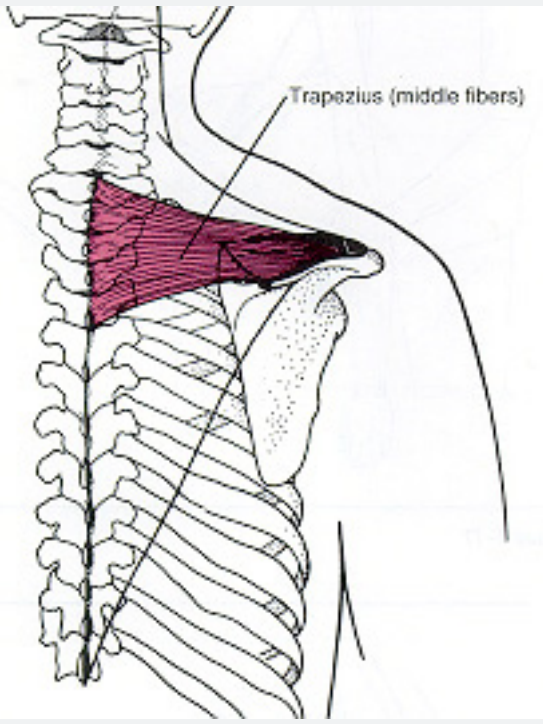
It should be noted that although increased loads are ideal for the upper trap, so too is the lifting angle. Pizzai et al. (2014) noted that with 30° of arm abduction (arms spread 30° from the side of the body) demonstrated increased upper trap recruitment. This would be best preformed with cables or bands at lower loads that can

be worked up. Equally, Ekstrom et al. (2003) also discovered that second to the shrug, prone (laying face down) reverse fly's at 135° of shoulder abduction with external rotation and the standing "full can" shoulder elevation raise above 120°, were two very powerful upper trap dominant exercises. You'll see throughout the program how much we love to hold the weight at the top after shrugs. This is a painfully effective technique that is our bread and butter. Feel free to experiment a bit with the other more exotic moves.

BEST ISOLATION EXERCISES:

1. Standing Barbell or Hex Bar Deadlift to banded shrug
2. Single Arm Banded Smith Machine Shrug
3. Banded Cross-over shrug with External arm rotation
4. Prone Neck Extension with "I" Raise and arm external rotation "full can"
5. Standing Banded Y raise "full can"

MIDDLE TRAP



The middle region of the trap originates from just below the upper trap, along the seventh cervical spine and inferiorly to the first thoracic spine process; with an insertion along the distal end of the collarbone closely to the AC joint of the shoulder (Johnson et al. 2005). The middle trap much like the upper, appears to generate maximum force production during neck extension and stabilizing scapular activities Ackland et al. (2011).

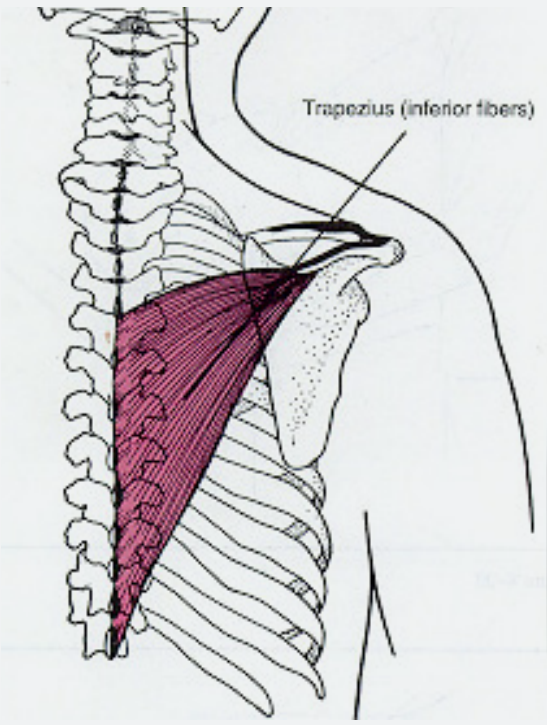
When investigating the middle traps pulling capability, several scientists (Lehman et al. 2004, Handa et al. 2005) have noted that the middle traps are best targeted through bent-over rows or other horizontal compound lifts such as the inverted row; as well the cable or machine horizontal row. Interestingly, a supinated grip appeared to have the greatest influence on middle trap recruitment due to the increased range of motion of the arm into shoulder extension. The topic on grip is still debatable as pronated grip studies showed increased trap recruitment due to minimized biceps influence but considering that less load can be lifted due to minimizing the synergistic assist from the biceps it may be more relevant to direct people as always to alternate and explore the difference in load and time under tension to maximize benefits as a whole.

Equally work preform by Ekstrom et al. (2003) noted increased middle trap activity with the prone reverse fly at 135° of shoulder abduction with and without external rotation combined with scapular retraction prior to lifting.

BEST ISOLATION EXERCISE:

1. Horizontal Rows
2. Prone Neck Extension with “T” raise and arm external rotation “full can”

LOWER TRAP



The Lower trap originates from the first thoracic vertebra, down to the seventh and inserts into the shoulder blade with some of its lowest fibers blending into the posterior delts bony projection along the arm bone (Johnson et al. 2005). The primary function of the lower trap is directed at scapular upward rotation; playing a more prominent role with upper arm motion. This is in contrast to the upper and middle region of the trap, where cervical spine extension, rotation and lateral bending occur.

Lower trap involvement occurs with arm motion, specifically during the first half range of the vertical pull, where scapular depression (setting the scaps downward) occurs as during the pullup and lat pulldown.

Ekstrom et al. (2003) and Moseley et al. (1992) identified that the prone Y with External rotation, standing Y "full can" and prone row, were the ideal isolating exercises for the lower trap. This makes any horizontal abduction angle to the body at or above 90 degrees at shoulder abduction key for muscle recruitment.

BEST ISOLATION EXERCISE:

1. Banded Face Pulls
2. Prone Neck Extension with "Y" Raise and arm external rotation "full can"

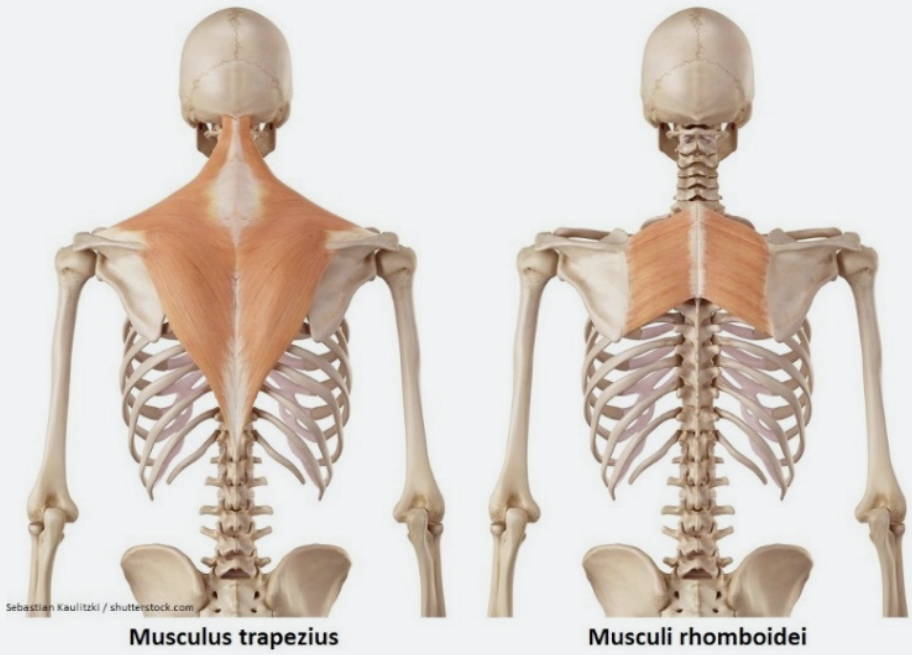
TRAINING THE TRAPS

Now, the traps appear to display a range of 28 - 62% slow twitch type 1 muscle fiber distribution (Eriksson et al. 2005) but can have outliers in the strength and powerlifting communities that can be seen with ranges around 64-79% (Kadi et al. 1998, 1999). This type of muscle fiber breakdown lends to the understanding that while strength athletes may respond better to heavier loads moved at faster speeds, there is still reason for mixing the intensity/rep ranges to also include lighter loads.

Work performed by Naddeo et al. (2008) demonstrated that for every increase in 10% of relative load, they saw a rise in upper trap recruitment. This identifies that the traps can be trained both within an endurance capacity but most likely best training through progressive overload, with increases occur incrementally with good attention to spine posture both when seated and when standing.

If we compare what tools are best to preform work to the traps as a whole, it appears that when we load the 1st and 2nd half of the concentric and eccentric portions of the range, we can see further improvements, but this is only achieved through the use of resistance bands or cam-based exercise machines such as the ones developed from Prime Fitness. This observation was noted by Bergquist (2015) when he compared dumbbells to elastic bands during the prone reverse fly. Luckily bands are cheap and easy to use.

RHOMBOIDS



The rhomboids (plural for 2; the Minor and Major) sit below a portion of the middle and lower trap, where they originate from the spine of the 2nd and 5th thoracic vertebra and insert into the medial border of the shoulder blade. Muscle fiber breakdown demonstrates that the rhomboids are predominantly fast twitch or phasic in nature. Hence their primary function becomes not only to adhere the shoulder blade onto the rib cage during a horizontal pulling movement (much like the serratus anterior does for pushing) but is also works with the levator scapulae; together producing downward rotation and retraction the shoulder blade.

This function of downward rotation and retraction actually occur simultaneously with arm extension, which occurs during the end range of a horizontal row.

Evidence suggests that scapular posture plays a large role when attempting to recruit the rhomboids. As just mentioned, the appropriate and correct cue for the row must be "squeeze the shoulder blades together and down and pull through the elbow to draw the arm into extension". One of the best was to directly impact rhomboid recruitment is to start with a chest supported horizontal row dubbed the "bat wing" by Dan John. The easiest way for me to coach this is to simply instruct someone to use that cueing during a cable low row.

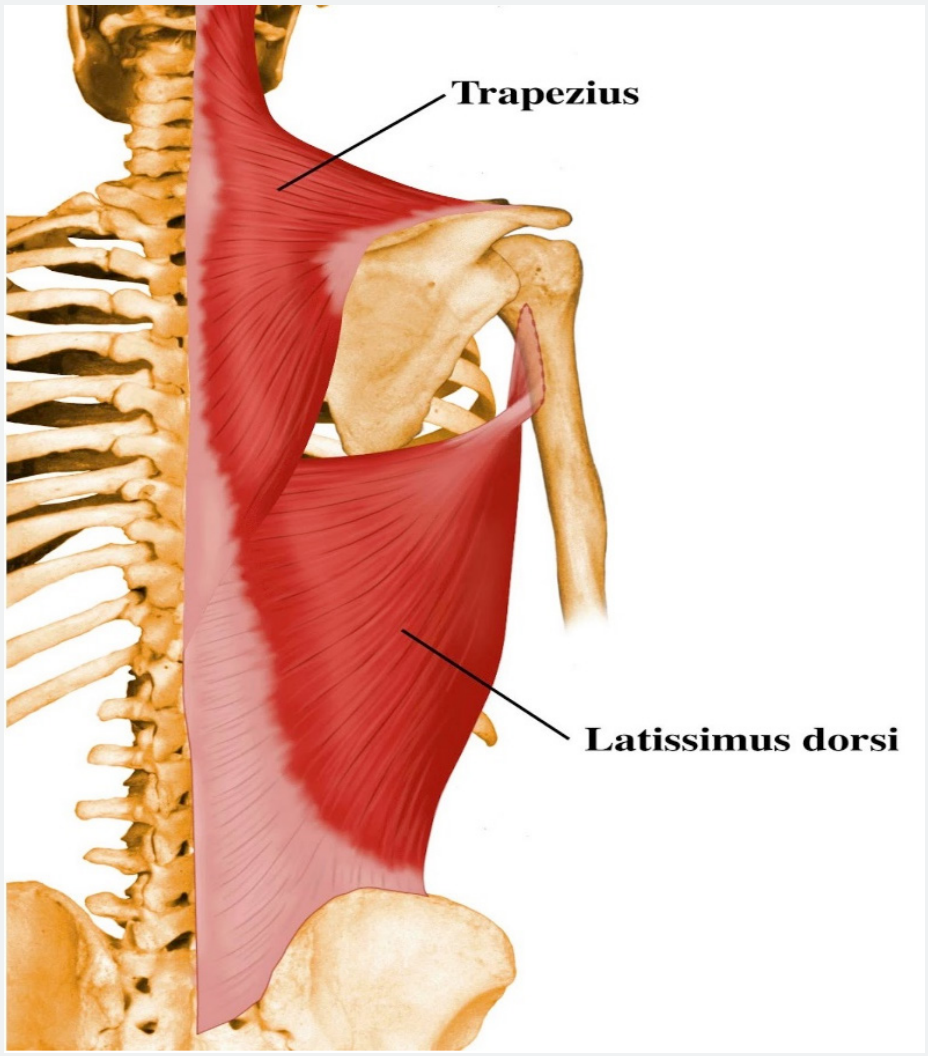
This exercise falls in line with research done by Lehman et al (2004) that demonstrated when combining scapular retraction with a row (seated row in this study) the middle trap and rhomboids

recruitment was greatest. The inclusion of a chest supported variation is based on literature from (Blank) that demonstrated chest-supported rows are best for trap and rhomboid recruitment, as with removing the need to stabilize via the erectors, decreased sway of trunk permitted greater torque and muscle recruitment along the middle trap and rhomboids.

BEST ISOLATION EXERCISE:

1. Inverted Row
2. 2 Bench supported prone Bat wing with optional chain or bands
3. Bent Over Meadows Row

LATISSIMUS



Known as the largest muscle of the upper body (Holzbaur et al., 2007) the Latissimus or Lats, contribute to both aesthetics and function for back training. These points can't be more exaggerated when considering the muscles anatomical area of coverage running the distance from your upper pelvis (superior iliac crest), lumbar spine/thoracic spine (thoracolumbar junction), ribs 12 to 10 and in some cases the shoulder blade (inferior scapular angle) and finally inserting onto the arm (anterior-medial bicipital groove) where it's tendon and the Teres Major tendon blend together (Bogduk et al., 1998; Carvalhais et al., 2013, Goldberg et al., 2009).

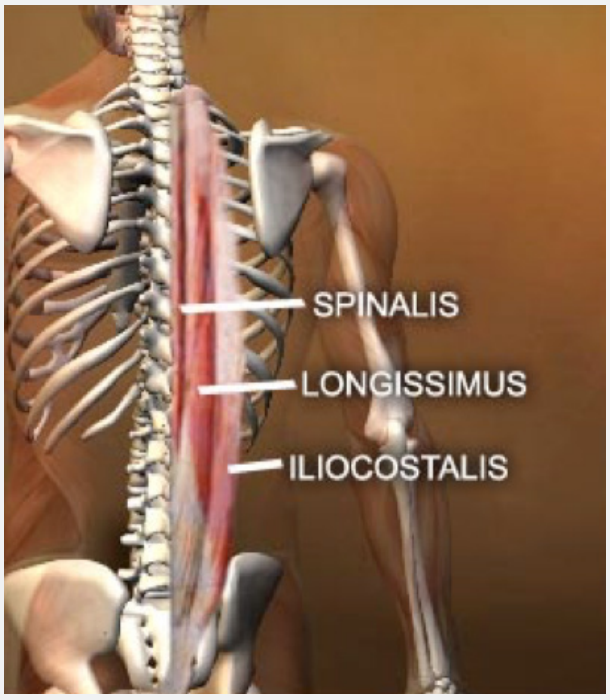
Functionally, the Lat can be divided into 3 regions, the superior, middle, and inferior (Ackland et al., 2008) that perform shoulder extension, adduction and internal or medial rotation. These 3 regions appear to have individual torque arms that make them better suited for pulling through various ranges of motion. Work done by Keuchle et al (2000) and Ackland et al. (2008) both demonstrate that the Lat has its peak torque between 30-50 degrees of shoulder flexion (Horizontal Pulling exercise), with a minimum noted at 120 degrees of shoulder flexion (Overhead Pulling exercise); and a peak adduction torque from 60-90 degree of shoulder abduction (below horizontal) with a minimum at 10 degrees abduction.

I know this may sound crazy to think pullups are not the best Lat exercise, but consider that angles, tension, and intention truly do play a role in muscle recruitment and development.

Increasing Lat recruitment appears to be linear from the overhead position towards the hips starting at around 80 degrees of shoulder flexion and plateauing near the 50 to 40-degree shoulder flexion position.

Dividing the Lat by regions really brings out an understanding on what ranges of shoulder flexion are best at optimizing muscle recruitment and time invested. We can consider that shoulder extension will occur more from a straight arm Lat pulldown, and the combination of extension, adduction, internal rotation will occur from a cable pulldown.

ERECTOR SPINAE



Finally, lets complete the isolated back training with the Erector Spinae (ES). The ES are cluster of muscles that contain 3 types of muscle connections that run from the sacrum (sit bone) all along the length of the spine to the skull and outwardly attach the pelvis to the ribs. These muscles in order from the spine and outward to the ribs are the spinalis, the longissimus and the illiocostalis. The grand total of ES muscles we have are 9 and this is why learning to train them can help to make some lasting impressions on overall back thickness as in the thoracic spine the muscles lay deep to the rhomboids and middle trap, but also in how they provide pelvic/hip control which is essential for living without back pain. I will also say this, I did at one time receive MAT treatment on my longissimus, and my squat strength rocketed up. Strengthening these muscles give you a lot of bang for your buck.

SPINALIS	LONGISSIMUS	ILLIOCOSTALIS
Capitis	Capitis	Cervisis
Cervicis	Cervisis	Thoracis
Thoracis	Thoracis	Lumborum

Let's dive into a quick review on their function as a group and what exercises will allow us to dominate their growth.

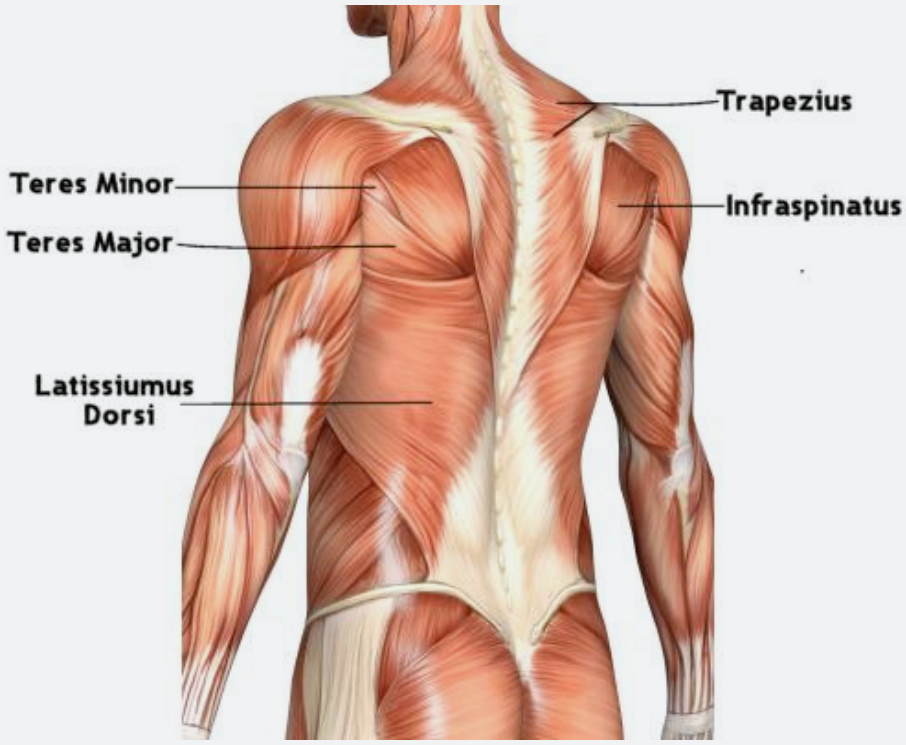
The ES muscles basic function is to control spine flexion, side bending, and rotation. This makes them ideal at controlling posture and henceforth work to provide a stable foundation for the legs and arms to hinge from through the hip and shoulder joint respectively. With exercises such as the GHD hyper extension, prone leg curl, RDL and good morning all showing high muscle recruitment McAllister et al. (2014), it is noted that they are worked quite frequently with compound movements.

Due to higher loads (85% 1 RM) producing greater muscle recruitment (McAllister et al. 2014) we should also respect that heavy loading direct work should be kept for end of session exercises as early fatigue may not be ideal before moving into higher risk movements such as with any Deadlift variation or Squat. Nonetheless, the GHD hyper or other named exercise can be tossed into an upper extremity day where it's placement is less critical; wherein the exercise would be programed to add in additional volume. Only if I am feeling very sick and twisted would direct lower back work precede a row or deadlift variation.

INFRASPINATUS & TERES MINOR

EXTRA CONTENT:

Although the Infraspinatus/Teres Minor is part of the rotator cuff, it makes up quite a significant role both aesthetically and functionally. Increased strength along the rotator cuff is important as we consider longevity of the shoulder joint and when it comes to back training, the shoulder joint as you can see with the traps and now rotator cuff and later lats, is the main structural/ anatomical contact point the bridges it all together.



Rotator cuff training gets a bad rap as "therapy only" exercises due to their lightweight training requirements. The emphasis for limiting the loads when performing isotonic or single joint exercises for the rotator cuff are due to how easy the rotator cuff muscle can be outperformed by surrounding larger muscle groups; such as the delts, pec, lat, biceps and triceps, which all cross the shoulder joint. In many cases when an injury occurs to the rotator cuff, which leads to weakness; you will find an increase in the likelihood of tendonitis along the respective muscle that were mentioned.

Now to effectively train these muscle that originate from the shoulder blade to the arm, we must understand their role. The rotator cuff as a whole (supraspinatus, infraspinatus, teres minor, subscapularis) all act to depress the head of the arm while performing movement. This means that they keep the ball seated in the socket; which can decrease the chance of a shoulder impingement. We will use the

acronym SITS to discuss the muscles independent function to better understand how to target them for growth.

S (Supraspinatus): Elevates the arm the first 30 degrees from the body with the arm in slight internal rotation.

- Best Isolation exercise: Leaning lateral raise
- *NOTE: These are worked into your shoulder routines!*

I (Infraspinatus): External rotation from arm at side through shoulder movement

- Best Isolation Exercise: Cable External rotation
- *NOTE: If you want to do these, do 4 sets of 15 before your chest and shoulders workout every 2 to 3 weeks.*

T (Teres Minor): External rotation with arm abduction above 90 as seen when throwing a ball

- Best Isolation Exercise: Cable, dumbbell or band external rotation from thrower position
- *NOTE: If you want to do these, do 4 sets of 15 before your chest and shoulders workout every 2 to 3 weeks.*

S (Subscapularis): Internal rotation from arm at side throughout shoulder movement

- Best Isolation Exercise: Cable Internal rotation from throwers position down to arm at side
- *NOTE: If you want to do these, do 4 sets of 15 before your chest and shoulders workout every 2 to 3 weeks.*

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ANGLES AND INTENSITY

Now let's talk more about deadlifts, rows, and pulls to enrich your knowledge in those key areas as well.

When we break down the back, we are truly discussing the synergistic effects of the Trapezius, Rotator Cuff, Rhomboids, Posterior Deltoid, Latissimus, and Erector Spinae. As a group, these muscles allow us to stabilize the spine during day to day tasks, as well lift and pull objects. If we breakdown the movements into these distinct three phases (or four if we divide pulling into horizontal and vertical) there is clear evidence that much of what can unleash your back-building potential has everything to do with angles.

THE DEADLIFT

Let's start with lifting objects such as the deadlift, which require our back muscles to act as stabilizers and to act synergistically with the legs and upper body to get the job done. To get a better understanding of how to view the deadlift I will break up its 3 distinct phases and talk about how to move beyond just the one movement to truly develop back thickness and width which is in line with what John discovered years ago throughout his own pursuit of mass and spine health.

As the staple of most lifters back day training, the deadlift has and will always be a critical movement that can yield quite a positive training effect along the back, posterior chain of the legs, the upper extremities and within the hormonal cascade that occurs with heavy weight training which is systemic by nature.

Nonetheless, there are many variables to growth with the deadlift; where simply loading more on the bar will not always yield in mass gains for all. Due to the distinct nature of the lift we can break down the movement into 2 distinct macro-phases I call the "ascent" and "descent". The ascending phase has 3 prominent micro-phases, 1) lift-off, 2) knee passage, and 3) top lock out; with the descending or return phase having more of an emphasis on the eccentric portion of the lift for adaptive growth and injury prevention.

In my experience, this "load or go home" mentality is why I see so many lifters walk in through my door, due to poor development and control throughout the each of the phases due to poor cueing "lift it and drop it", "grind it out!", or "lock out with your spine". These cues are why I train individuals who deadlift to break down the lift into 4 phases and spend some time using a "bodybuilding" approach which ensures positive growth and strength gains where they individually need it most. I would rather keep someone on the road to training than on the road to rehab but that is because I am a lifter at heart and know the stress that comes from having to shut it down for even a couple weeks at best.

PHASES OF THE DEADLIFT

ASCENDING PHASE

Phase 1 - The Lift-off: Point at which the bar leaves the ground to just below the knee

- Muscles most active during this phase:
  - Middle Trapezius: Escamilla et al. (2002) demonstrated peak contraction of the mid-trap during the early lift off phase where the body is in a most horizontal position (bent over) just before knee passage.
  - Erector Spinae: Escamilla et al. (2002) demonstrated recruitment but no difference between the upper vs lower fibers during this phase.

Phase 2 – Knee passage: Point at which the bar passes over the knee to just before the bar clears the hips.

- Muscles most active during this phase:
  - Upper Trapezius: Carb et al. (2014) & Escamilla et al. (2002) both reported the knee passage phase to be a more effective range for the Upper Trap recruitment than during the lift off phase.
  - Erector Spinae: Escamilla et al. (2002) demonstrated recruitment but no difference between the upper vs lower fibers during this phase.

Phase 3 – Top lock out: Point at which the hips can lock out into extension through active glute contraction NOT lumbar spine hyperextension.

- Muscles most active during this phase:
  - Upper Trapezius: Again Carb et al. (2014) & Escamilla et al. (2002) both reported peak upper Trap muscle activity during the top lockout of the deadlift.

DESCENDING PHASE

Phase 1 – The Descent (Return): Point at which eccentric control of the bar is critical for building injury resilience.

- Muscles most active during this phase:
  - Erector Spinae: Escamilla et al. (2002) reported following conventional and sumo deadlift variations no difference was found between the ascending or descending phases in either variable but that both upper and lower erector spinae muscle activity was seen to be highest during the return or descending phase (knee passage to lift-off). This finding provides insight to the importance that controlling the descending phase of the deadlift has on training the erector spinae muscle.

This last phase is often forgotten in the more "functional" side of the world where to ditch the bar from the top lock out is a sort of mic drop. Hey if the weight is that heavy that the descent can injure you, then please spend time building this up to A reduce that threat and B show some balls! No, in honesty the bail out is necessary for

most in competition but should not be common place in the world of training and most obviously not bodybuilding.

As the body transitions through these phase, speed will determine the time spent in each portion of the lift, which can vary widely among lifters as too so will the leverage angles. The variations in human anatomy both structurally and metabolically will determine much of the benefit a deadlift can have for some, but regardless finding the safest way possible to implement the dead-lift is key.

The data mentioned above should allow for clarity as to why John implements variations of the dead lift to target key areas of the Traps, Erector Spinae and the Lats.

Warm Up

EXECUTION

I'll allow a recent video from John and Eugene from http://www.coacheugeneteo.com/ talk about the 3 key steps for properly setting up the deadlift.

Master The Deadlift In 3 Easy To Follow Tips

RANDOM POINTS FOR THE DEADLIFT

- As far as the Sumo or Conventional Deadlift are concerned, Escamilla et al. (2002) found there to be no difference in recruitment of the upper, middle traps nor erector spinae muscle activity.
- No difference noted by Grostand et al. (2013) between powerlifting vs weightlifting bars for upper or middle trap recruitment.
- Although lighter loads can be used for trap development through specific isolation exercises which we will cover later on, it still appears that heavier loads (80% 1RM) are best to work up to with compound lifting, as seen by Beggs et al. (2011) when comparing

load ranges of 60-80% 1RM during the deadlift for trap recruitment.

- No Upper Trap muscle activity found when comparing matched (double overhand grip) and alternating (over-under grip) Beggs et al. (2011)
- Beggs et al. (2011) reported that when comparing 60 and 80% of 1RM loads, the latissimus dorsi displayed significantly muscle activity during the double overhand condition
- However, at 80% of 1RM, no difference was found when comparing the double overhand and mixed grip in regards to lat muscle activity.
- Erector spinae muscle activity was similar when comparing a conventional deadlift at 50% of 1RM standing on the floor vs standing on a BOSU ball. Bressel et al. (2009)
- Speed did not affect erector spinae recruitment Noe et al. (1992)
- Back squats appear to produce more erector spinae muscle activity than the conventional deadlift. Willardson et al. (2009) However when Nuzzo et al. (2008) compared muscle activity at 90% of 1RM, erector muscle activity was higher in the deadlift in the upper erector spinae and lower erector spinae. Stating that at higher intensities the deadlift was more efficient than the squat for upper erector spinae activity but not so clear at to the lower.
- Hamlyn et al. (2007) reported that the back squat and deadlift when performed with 80% of 1RM demonstrated increased lower and upper erector muscle activity when compared to a face down superman pose over a physio-ball and the side plank. GET IN YOUR DEADLIFTS!
- Nuzzo et al. (2008) reported increased upper and lower erector spinae activity when performing the conventional deadlift and back squat (50 – 100% of 1RM) to the bird dog (quadruped arm-and-leg lift), and a hip thruster from a swiss ball. Equally when preforming the deadlift and squat with near 90% 1 RM these exercises preformed more superior to all of the core (front plank, side plank, superman and quadruped arm-and-leg lift) regardless of stability requirements (Flat surface vs Bosu).

HORIZONTAL PULLING (THE ROW)

The row is by far another tried and true exercise for developing the traps, lats, and erectors! Let's jump in!

The row should make up the largest part of your back development. Why? It has to do with its ability to increase size across most all of the back muscles while being by far the safest on the shoulder and low back.

Having said that the row can be executed through many different variations. From free weight, TRX, cables to machines; the assortment can make anyone new to the world of bodybuilding dizzy. What any seasoned lifter will tell you first and foremost is "you must feel what you intend to grow". The mind muscle connection is vital and has shown to have promising effects especially in latissimus development as seen by Snyder et al. (2009) when demonstrating a 13% increase in latissimus MVC with verbal cueing and palpation (touching the muscle).

Equally, work by Lehman et al. (2004) showed a relative increase in latissimus recruitment when performing the row with full scapula retraction; which requires feedback and cueing upon execution.

Before we dive into any more literature, take a quick break and check out another recent video from John and Eugene where they discuss the how to properly feel the back when rowing. Effect of horizontal row technique

Can't Activate Back Muscles | How 2 Solve That Problem

COMPARE THE ROWS

Now that we have set the stage for how and what to feel "thanks guys!", lets hit up John's and my favorite type of rows and why we should be doing more of them.

INVERTED ROWS

TARGET: THE LATS

TRX at one point was all the craze, and I too was skeptical on body weight exercises having any true long-term benefits as overloading them would be limited to having to wear chains, bands or a putting on weighted vest. Well it turns out back in 2009 Fenwick et al. took a look at latissimus dorsi activity and concluded superior muscle activity during the inverted row when compared to the bent over barbell row and the single arm cable row when loads are matched.

Newer evidence from Youdas et al. (2015) compared forearm orientation during the inverted row and demonstrated that a supinated grip produced superior latissimus dorsi muscle activity as when compared to a pronated grip variation. The TRX straps make this aspect a bit easier on the wrist but by no means are more superior to a barbell inverted row as seen by Snarr et al. (2013) who demonstrated no difference between the barbell vs TRX on lat muscle activity.

What this means is that at lighter loads, the TRX or suspension inverted row is a powerhouse which should be included in your routine.

Inverted Rows

HANGING CHEST SUPPORTED ROWS/BENT-OVER ROWS

TARGET: THE MID AND UPPER TRAP

Hanging chest supported rows fall into this same category but place a larger emphasis on the traps vs the lats as seen by bent over row data which placed similar angular demand on the body with less low back stress (think longevity of the back over showman ship). Work done by Handa et al. (2005), demonstrated superior Mid and Upper Trap muscle activity during the bent over row when compared to other rowing variations. Many row variations can be used here with your personal ability to feel the working muscle playing the biggest role in selecting which variation you want.

Here is a great example of a chest supported row using a slightly wider grip to influence more posterior delt recruitment which is a product of reducing the demand of balance with the chest supported variation.

Rear Delts

I personally love combining the deadlift to pendlay row with a trap bar. This method can tac on 2 variations of the row for the traps that are killer; while the use of the trap bar can decrease lumbar shear as the weight can be placed closer to the spine.

Using a Trap Bar

Equally a banded bent over single arm dumbbell row is a cool way to introduce accommodating resistance to the peak contraction phase of the lift with little work needed to achieve this.

Banded bent over dumbbell rows

CABLE/MACHINE ROWS

TARGET: THE LATS

Not all cable and machine rowing devices are made equal. With the rise of companies like PRIME FITNESS with their "SmartStrength" technology which actually allows you to load along the strength curve (a bell-shaped curve that explains why you are strongest in the mid-range of an exercise and weakest at the extremes of full contraction and stretch). These systems are applying better science to our familiar cable and machine weights that truly do make a more efficient evidence-based workout for mass.

Prime Row Machines 1 Prime Row Machines 2
Prime Row Machines 3

Work done by Handa et al. (2005) demonstrated superior lat muscle activity during seated rows (cable/machine) as when compared to the bent over barbell row at 70% 1 RM. This is most likely to improved control of the row without need to stabilize the low body where fatigue in the posterior chain of muscles, including the back may result in a change of loading angle and place more emphasis again on the traps.

Why Rows can vary on trap and lat recruitment has to do with arm angle which can vary from wide grip that targets more of the posterior delts, rhomboids and traps with a narrower grip affecting the lats. The range that appears to truly light up the lat is a pull from about 60 degrees of shoulder flexion. This was noted from work by Park et al. (2013) when they compared pulling angles of 120, 90, 60 degrees of shoulder flexion. 90-60 degrees both were superior to 120 degrees with the highest being noted at 60.

Some options when you don't have access to the equipment are setting up a cable machine with a low or high pulley setting.

Low Pulley Row High Pulley Row

Here is a killer cable variation from John's own mind that will blow your lats up!

Cable Variation

Landmine Rows

I think it would be downright wrong to leave out one of John's biggest contributions to the field of back training if we didn't discuss the Meadows Row.

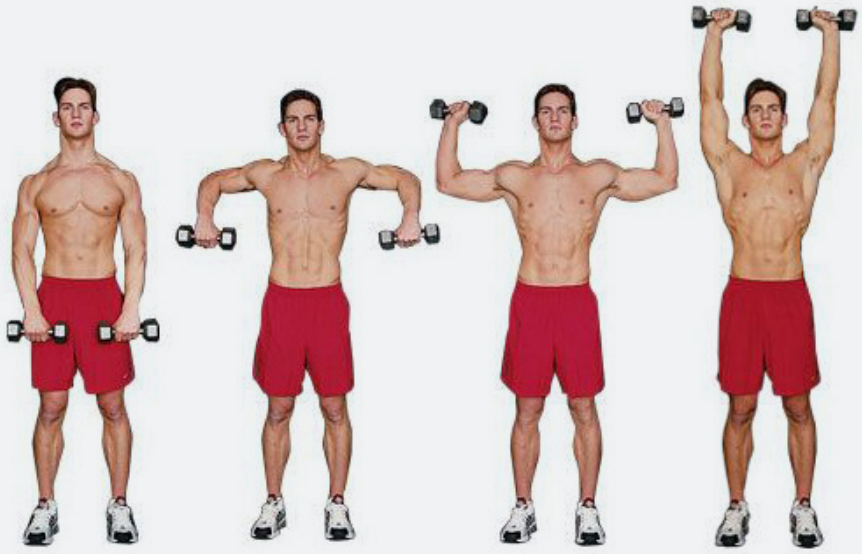
With much of the bent over row data and lumbar spine shear data suggesting that although bent over rows are a good tool, we must use caution with the lumbar spine when overloading; introduce the single arm landmine variation to positively mix things up.

The classic Meadows row, and the variations that have spawn from it do have in the trenches results with many clients having gained quality and quantifiable muscle. The true benefits to executing this movement has to do with the ability to alter the leverage angle of the weight while providing a safer body posture due to the 3 points of contact (2 feet, 1 hand/elbow). This movement is and has been a staple in my programming for years now and has effectively allowed many of my own patients to return to rowing and eventually deadlifting following back pain and even surgery.

The Upright-Row

When comparing compound movements such as the upright row, seated cable row, bent over row, and lat pulldown (front or rear) which was performed by Handa et al. in 2005; this group found that upper trap recruitment was highest during the upright row, followed

by the bent over row, and lastly the seated row. Again, both I and John will stress to understand that upper trap development can be achieved while avoiding shoulder impingement, which I will cover later on.



Because there is still debate on wide grip vs narrow grip variations I will break down the highlights for the big picture.

- When considering peak upper and mid trap development with reduced risk for shoulder impingement the 200% of shoulder width grip (wide outside of shoulder width) is the key. (McAllister et al. 2013)
- Equally 100% of shoulder width grip (shoulder width exactly) was far superior for upper trap activity than the 50% shoulder width grip (narrow). (McAllister et al. 2013)

This information is useful for understanding the benefits of implementing a progressive Cuban press into your lifting strategy; starting with very light weight (1-4lbs) and working up to 10lbs but truly not needing to go any heavier unless the goal is to begin incorporating Olympic lifting.

Here is a starting free weight kneeling variation (could be performed in sitting) for developing stronger and more injury resilient shoulders

Kneeling Overhead Rotator Cuff Eccentrics

Here is an option to the Cuban press I use with good outcomes for complete trap recruitment and injury prevention.

Band Face Pull To Cuban Overhead Press

PULLUPS/PULLDOWNS

Finally, to the pulldowns!

So much of what people think of back training has to do with the pulldown or pullups. What is unfortunate is how quickly this exercise can be butchered into following with what is written in magazines and internet experts on YouTube with no credentials nor years of experience within their own training and that of client outcomes.

As John has stated before, sometimes it takes a bit of "insanity" to get the job done right, but what we don't want to do is continue to repeat the same task that has yielded no results and expect a new outcome. What we need is some science to help point the way.

Right off the bat, lets dive into the front or rear lat pulldown variations.

When I was in my doctoral program, we had an exercise course where an instructor told us that behind the back pulldowns were the best for lat development and lower trap development but not the safest for the shoulder joint. Well, this instructor wasn't exactly wrong but like most, not the best informed. Work done by Handa et al. (2005), and Sperandei et al. (2009) both demonstrated no difference between the 2 variations, which included a third variation in the later of the 2 studies. This is important to state because it identifies that we can chose a safer, front loaded pulldown with less risk to the shoulder joint.

Of the available literature only one study that I am aware of, in 2002 by Signorile et al. demonstrating that a front lat pulldown was significantly better than the rear lat pulldown for lat activity when a wide grip was used.

This concept of grip width is a common one in the bodybuilding world, with again much debate due to variations in our anatomy. What we can do is start with a basis of validated general data and build from there.

THE GRIPS - Andersen et al. (2014), Lusk et al. (2010)

Standardized to the lifters shoulder width via the bony projection known as the acromion.

- Narrow: 1 bi-acromial width or hands just at or slightly outside of shoulder width apart
- Medium: 1.5 bi-acromial width or hands outside of shoulder width
- Wide: 2 times bi-acromial width or hands greater than shoulder width apart

The variations of grip are quite clear, there is really no difference in lat muscle activity throughout the grip widths with the one aforementioned study by Signorile et al. (2002) demonstrating a front, wide grip being superior.

What has shown to have an impact though is forearm orientation. Literature done by Lusk et al (2010) and Lehman et al. (2004) both concluded that a using a pronated, wide, front pulldown had the most superior lat muscle activity as compared to a supinated, neutral grip, front pulldown.

Some variations to pulldown are using variable cable positions or loading patterns which is where the PRIME equipment rolls in again. Because pulldowns can be performed individually through cable handles, where a single arm variation is used, there can be more emphasis on full range of motion which involves the following cues.

1. Depress the scap
2. Externally rotate the arm
3. Pull the elbow down into the pelvis
4. Slightly side-bend the trunk to shorten the origin to the insertion for peak contraction

How to warm up the Lats for pulldowns.

Because we know cueing is so important here is a drill I use with my clients to get them truly locked into what the lat should feel like.

Warm Up Strategy

PULLUP

In the world of bodybuilding, luckily there are no steadfast "rules" to competition that require you to learn how to perform a kipping pullup. Regardless of the large shoulder demands that a kipping pullup requires, work done by Snarr et al. (2013) and Youdas et al. (2010) demonstrated that when considering lat and even middle/lower trap muscle activity for strength, the traditional pronated grip pullup or strict pullup was far superior to the kipping, and even a towel or supinated grip pullup. Shocking news I know.

SCALE UP THE PULLUP

1. Perform a hang while in good shoulder posture which is, keeping the shoulder blades tucked down (depressed) to maintain an open space between your ears and the shoulder blade. Try this every time to you going to wrap up an exercise session regardless if you are not doing back.
    a. Perform 4 sets of 5 reps with a 10 second hold for 2 weeks.
2. Progress to a jump and hold, and work on slow eccentric return to the hang. This will require you to use a step box at first as you scale up. Use a similar approach but only during back days and 1 additional training day.
    a. Perform 4 sets of 5 reps with a 7 second hold and a 4 second drop for 2 weeks.
3. Build your tolerance to 2 pullups per day for the first week, and then increase by 1 rep per week until you get to 5 and then start adding 1 additional rep every other 2 days. Stop when you get to 10 which should be between about 12 weeks in total of training which is ideal and quite normal to get down this movement pattern with enough efficiency.

6-WEEK BACK TRAINING PROGRAM

Ok now that we have laid down the basic foundational knowledge you need, let's get you on your way to building a wide and thick back!

Next up – The program.

We lay out the split for you and give you an idea of volume and frequency of other bodyparts, but the emphasis is of course on your back.

In order to understand how close to failure you should take each set, there is an RPE chart below, that will tell you exactly how hard to go. It is very important that you follow this to the letter.

Rate of Perceived Exertion Flow Chart	
Fairly easy like a warm-up weight	@ 6.0
You can do 4-6 more reps	@ 7.0
You can do 2-3 more reps	@ 8.0
You have 2 more reps left in the tank	@ 8.5
You have 1 more rep left in the tank	@ 9.0
Went to failure at perfect form	@ 10
Went to failure with loose form after perfect reps completed	@ 11
Used a high intensity technique to push beyond failure	@ 12
Used multiple high intensity techniques/go apeshit set!	@ 13

Click on any one of the tags for an example

To kick off this Back Manual I'm linking a lat activation video. Watch this video, try the technique, and apply it ANYTIME you need to feel your lats contract better.

Back Activation | How To Feel Your Lats

WEEK 1

Monday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***12 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	4 sets
	5 exercises	16 sets

Tuesday		
Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	8 exercises	27 sets

Wednesday		
Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	5 exercises	17 sets

Thursday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***12 sets***
Biceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	6 exercises	18 sets

Friday - Off

Saturday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***16 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	6 exercises	26 sets

Sunday - Off - Family Day

WEEK 1 - MONDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*12 sets*
Abs	1 exercises	4 sets

Back: Monday will be heavily focused on rowing and a variation of the deadlift. The goal here is to create thickness in your back, and the way to achieve that is tried and true heavy rowing.

1/ **Back** | One arm barbell row

After a few warm up sets, I want you to get right into your working weight. We will do 3 total sets with this weight. The goal is 10 reps on each arm, but by the third set you may lose 1 or 2 reps. I am giving you two videos here on how to do them with just the bar or with the attachment from EliteFTS. ***3 total work sets***

1 arm barbell rows with IFBB Pro Andrew Hudson

or

One arm barbell row

These sets are all RPE of 9.
Goal – Activation and start pump

Pro Tip

Use your free arm to generate a push into your leg. This will create a counter force to aid in stiffening your low back muscles to help you pull harder and safer. NOTE: If you happen to be dealing with low grade back pain and want to use a belt, feel free to apply it as a work around.

2/ **Back** | Smith machine row

Let's go right into another rowing movement. Watch the video to see how every single rep is from a dead stop. Do not lose tension in your lats, the pause is to remove momentum, not to take a break. Give me 3 total work sets. The first set get 12, add some weight to the bar. The second set should be 10 reps, again add some weight to the bar. And for your final set, make that a HARD 8. Leave nothing in the tank. ***3 total work sets***

Smith Machine Rest Pause Bent Over Rows

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

Pro Tip

Really push your hips back to load the hamstrings and glutes. These muscles will be your foundation and will aid in allowing your low back to not attempt to work in isolation which can lead to poor form. You'll have to stand very close to the bar to achieve this, probably right up on it.

3/ **Back** | Dumbbell rows

I'm giving you this video, so you don't think, "this is my third row for the day, let's just pump and squeeze." I want 3 heavy sets of 8 before we move to deadlifts. ***3 total work sets***

190 lb dumbell rows at UM

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

Pro Tip

Just like with the one arm barbell row; use your free hand to press away from you, into the dumbbell rack or bench. This pressing away will allow you to create the counter torque needed to pull more while protecting your back.

4/ **Back** | Deadlifts

I want you to pyramid up to a weight that is a hard 8. After that set reduce the bar weight by 40% but add 2 chains per side. If you do not have chains that is ok (I just wanted you to have the same fun I had), just reduce the weight by 25% and go to failure. This is where it gets really fun, while maintaining perfect form, work to positive failure. The goal should be somewhere around 15-20 if you picked the right weight. Go all out! We will call this 3 sets. ***3 total work sets***

Pro Tip

Don't bounce the barbell off the ground as in the "touch and go" method. Use a small pause at the bottom to reset your hips and proper spine form. This will be key as fatigue sets in. Stay tight and listen to your body.

NOTE: If your form is about to go south, STOP! We do not ever want a sloppy deadlift rep!

Chain Deadlifts

These sets are all RPE of 9-10, then final set 13
Goal – Train explosively

NOTE: This is ONLY 12 working sets, but you should feel pretty wiped out after this. Plus, we have back 2 more times this week, so don't get any cute ideas about increasing volume.

TUESDAY

Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercises	6 sets

WEDNESDAY

Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

WEEK 1 - THURSDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*12 sets*
Biceps	2 exercises	6 sets

NOTE: Please don't just ignore the RPE chart here. When I say leave reps in the tank, I mean it. There is a method here. We can't slaughter our back all three workouts. We need to stimulate it but keep it fresh for Saturday because we will be hitting back again. Today's focus will be on pulldowns, chins and pullovers. Think width here!!

1/ **Back** | Supinated pulldown variation

Do a few warm up sets really focusing on feeling your lower lats squeeze hard. Today do 3 sets of 10 here. Leave a rep or two in the tank on all sets. ***3 total work sets***

Single Arm Pulldowns

These sets are all RPE of 8-9
Goal – Activation and Supramax pump

Pro Tip

Notice the slight side bend to the working side. We are not trying to do oblique work, but this side bend (lateral spinal flexion) is another function of the lat to create even more tension.

2/ **Back** | Pulldowns with a forced stretch

After the supinated pulldowns your lats should have an almost cramping pump in them. Let's stretch these bad boys out. I want 3 sets of 10 reps where you have your partner push you into an even deeper stretch. Watch how the forced stretch raises not only Fouad's scapula but also his butt comes off the seat slightly. ***3 total work sets***

Pulldowns with a forced stretch with IFBB Pro Fouad Abiad

These sets are all RPE of 8-9.
Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

Pro Tip

If you train solo, let the weight pull you out of the seat, which means you need to select a heavier load than if you had a partner. Stay in the stretched position for 2 seconds before driving the bar down to your forehead.

3/ **Back** | Hammer strength high row

I attached the video, so you could see the machine I was talking about. If you do not have this exact machine, just find something that most closely simulates it. Do NOT do the intensity technique in the video, as I want you seated the entire time with an RPE of 9 not 13. Give me 3 sets of 12, 10 and 8 for this exercise. ***3 total work sets***

Hammer Pulldown Variation

These sets are all RPE of 9
Goal – Supramax pump

4/ **Back** | Banded pullovers

If you have done any of the recent Mountain Dog Training programs you know how great this exercise is. Let's finish off today with 3 sets of 10 of pullovers. ***3 total work sets***

Banded Pullovers

These sets are all RPE of 10.
Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

FRIDAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 1 - SATURDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*16 sets*
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

**Time to really bring the pain and pump. Do a couple warm up rounds to get a pump and find the right load of each exercise. Rest 3 minutes between rounds before starting again. ENJOY!!*

Giant Sets

1/ **Back** | Rope straight arm pulldown

Attach a rope (or 2 if you are lucky enough to have 2 matching ropes in your gym). I want sets of 12 here really trying to drive as much blood into your lats as possible. These should make you have an even better connection to your lats with your pullups.

Superset with

2/ **Back** | Chins

For this exercise feel free to use the assisted machine if you need to or a band, if not bang out your reps on the bar. The goal is 8 reps per set. Go to video below to see the banded chins and a version of the straight arm pulldown.

4 Exercise Workout | For A Wide Back

Superset with

3/ **Back** | Low cable rows

Attach 2 single handles here to get a little extra range of motion. Stick with hard sets of 8 reps. Pay close attention to lowering the weight with your lats and just not letting it fly down.

Superset with

4/ **Back** | Kettlebell rows

If you do not have kettlebells, use dumbbells here. The contraction with the kettlebells are just better in my opinion. Do sets of 8 here to finish off the giant set. ***Do 4 rounds for a total of 16 work sets***

Kettlebell row

These sets are all RPE of 10-12.

SUNDAY - FAMILY DAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 2

Monday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***14 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	4 sets
	5 exercises	18 sets

Tuesday		
Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	8 exercises	27 sets

Wednesday		
Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	5 exercises	17 sets

Thursday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***12 sets***
Biceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	6 exercises	18 sets

Friday - Off

Saturday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***16 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	6 exercises	26 sets

Sunday - Off - Family Day

WEEK 2 - MONDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*14 sets*
Abs	1 exercises	4 sets

Back: Same structure as last week, but each week we will add a tad bit of volume this week.

1/ **Back** | Dumbbell rows

This was third in rotation last week, but we are moving it up in order today. All I need here is the classic pyramid. After a few warm up sets of 10 to get blood into your lats, give me 2 additional feeder sets, then 4 working sets of 8. See the chart for an example of how this would look. The goal is to get to heavy weight without wearing yourself out, hence the feeder sets. ***4 total work sets***

30# x 10 reps (warm up set)
50# x 10 reps (warm up set)
70# x 4 reps (feeder set)
80# x 4 reps (feeder set)
90# x 8 reps (1st work set)
100# x 8 reps (2nd work set)
110# x 8 reps (3rd work set)
115# x 8 reps (4th work set) I couldn't have done a 9th rep with perfect form

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Activation and start pump

2/ **Back** | D.Y. row

After all those sets of dumbbell rows, you are going to be glad I'm letting you sit down. Get into the hammer strength machine or a similar machine that closely simulates this, press your chest into the pad and get your elbows back. I want 2 hard sets of 8, then do the exact set Ken Jackson is doing in the video. So, you will do your set of 8, then tack on 6 forced reps, plus a 10 second partner assisted stretch. This should drive a massive amount of blood into your lats. ***3 total work sets***

Ifbb Ken Jackson doing some Hammer machine rows

These first 2 sets are 9-10 then the 3rd set is 13 RPE
Goal – Supramax pump

3/ **Back** | One arm barbell row

You think we are letting off the gas here? Nope, it's time for some one arm barbell rowing, but we are adding some progressive resistance in the form of chains if you have them. If not, that is ok. Knock out 4 sets of 8 each arm. If sweat isn't pouring from your nose by this point, you picked too light of weights or are resting too much between sets. ***4 total work sets***

One arm barbell row with chains

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

4/ **Back** | Rack pulls

Set the bar up so it is starting mid-shin. After a couple feeder sets, find a perfect weight for 6 reps where you can still generate force without grinding. I want you to fully let the bar rest on the pins before exploding up. At the top of each rep, try to flex your lats as hard as possible, as this will help with back thickness. Remember to retract your scapulae at the end for even more back work. Do 3 work sets here. ***3 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 8-9
Goal – Train explosively

TUESDAY

Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercises	6 sets

WEDNESDAY

Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

WEEK 2 - THURSDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*12 sets*
Biceps	2 exercises	6 sets

1/ **Back** | Away facing pulldowns

You can't go super heavy on these because you will come out of the seat. But, this is a great exercise to start a pump day with to get tons of blood just in the lats. The goal is to work the bottom part of the range of motion, not the stretch, the hardest. Use a bar that is about shoulder width grip and give me 3 sets of 10. ***3 total work sets***

Pro Tip

In the video you see a perfect example of how I want your elbows to be driven straight down. Once at full contraction, squeeze your elbows towards your ribs for an almost cramping sensation to your lats.

Away facing pulldown with IFBB Pro's Andrew Hudson and Shaun Clarida

These sets are all RPE of 8-9
Goal – Activation and Supramax pump

2/ **Back** | Underhand pulldown

If you have this machine at your gym, great. If not, simply sub in the underhand Mag-grip or an EZ bar attachment. Notice the stretch and contraction in the video on every single rep. Give me 3 working sets of 10 reps. ***3 total work sets***

Hammer Strength Supinated Pulldown

These sets are all RPE of 8-9.
Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

Pro Tip

Posture on this exercise is huge. Make sure your chest stays in contact with the pad the entire set. Do not use any lumbar extension to get more reps or ROM. If you end up just doing partials by your last set that is perfectly fine. We want all lats here.

3/ **Back** | Chins

Three total sets here with 3 different grips. On set 1 let's do wide grip, set 2 do just outside of shoulder width grip, and the final set neutral narrow grip. You can do these with bodyweight, with added weight, with the help of bands, or the assist machine. I want around 10 reps on all 3 sets. ***3 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 9
Goal – Supramax pump

4/ **Back** | Banded pullovers

Same as last week but I want 3 sets 12 with the exact same weight and band tension.

3 total work sets

Banded pullovers

These sets are all RPE of 10.

Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

FRIDAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 2 - SATURDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*16 sets*
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

1/ **Back** | Rope straight arm pulldown

Attach a rope (or 2 if you are lucky enough to have 2 matching ropes in your gym). I want sets of 12 here really trying to drive as much blood into your lats as possible.

Superset with

2/ **Back** | Low cable rows

Form and reps stay the same but change the handle to the narrow neutral grip. Stick with hard sets of 10 reps. Pay close attention to lowering the weight with your lats and just not letting it fly down.

Superset with

3/ **Back** | Kettlebell rows

If you do not have kettlebells, use dumbbells here. ***Do sets of 10 here.***

Kettlebell row

Superset with

4/ **Back** | Face Pulls

So you simply head back over to where you started, sit down on a box or a bench and do 10 pulls to your chest. This will put a hurting on your upper back. ***4 rounds for a total of 16 work sets.***

Face pulls

These sets are all RPE of 10-12.

Pro Tip

Maintain a slightly elevated head position to lock in the upper trap. This will allow you to gain some extension through your mid back (thoracic spine) which will help your shoulder blades move better when executing the row.

Pro Tip

Set up the pulley just above head level; this will allow you to slightly lean back to gain access to higher weight for overload.

SUNDAY - FAMILY DAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 3

Monday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***16 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	4 sets
	5 exercises	20 sets

Tuesday		
Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	8 exercises	27 sets

Wednesday		
Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	5 exercises	17 sets

Thursday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***12 sets***
Biceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	6 exercises	18 sets

Friday - Off

Saturday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***16 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	6 exercises	26 sets

Sunday - Off - Family Day

WEEK 3 - MONDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*16 sets*
Abs	1 exercises	4 sets

1/ **Back** | Meadows rows

We are 3 weeks in and finally get some Meadows row action going. We are going to kick off the day with a pyramid up and then a massive drop set. See chart for an example of how to do this as far as sets go. ***4 total work sets***

Meadows rows - 3 different techniques

These sets are all RPE of 9-10 and 4th set is 13
Goal – Activation and start pump

25# x 12 reps (warm up set)
35# x 12 reps (warm up set)
50# x 12 reps (warm up set)
75# x 4 reps (feeder set)
100# x 10 reps (1st work set)
100# x 10 reps (2nd work set)
100# x 9 reps (3rd work set)
100# x 8 reps -> 75# x 8 -> 50# x 10 -> 25# x 15 (4th work set)

2/ **Back** | E-z bar cable row

Time to head over to the cables and focus 100% on the contraction in your low lats. Notice the weight is not being extended into a full stretch. Give me 4 total set of 10 reps here. ***4 total work sets***

Low cable row w/ EZ curl bar

These sets are 9-10 RPE
Goal – Supramax pump

3/ **Back** | Deadstop dumbbell rows

Coming off the last contraction-based exercise this is going to feel amazing. In the video notice how with every rep there is an extreme, but safe, stretch on your lat. I want 4 hard sets of 8 here before we move onto some low back work. ***4 total work sets***

Dumbell Deadstop Rows

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

Pro Tip

As before, don't bounce the weight off the ground before you lift. Use a small pause, that will allow you to reset and maximally drive the weight up.

4/ **Back** | Banded hyperextension

Ok let's work your low back. This is a great exercise that we can attack with little chance of injury compared to deadlifts or rack pulls. You will ideally need 3 long red bands from EliteFTS. See chart for how this should look. You could also sub out any number of red bands for long orange micro mini bands. ***4 total work sets***

Pro Tip

Do some ab crunches to move blood out of back and you'll be relieved of the painful lower back pump much quicker.

Set 1 - Bodyweight x 10 (5 second squeeze at contraction)

Set 2 - 1 red band x 10 (4 second squeeze at contraction)

Set 3 - 2 red bands x 10 (3 second squeeze at contraction)

Set 4 - 3 red bands x 8 (2 second squeeze at contraction) -> 2 red bands x 6 (1 second pause at contraction) -> 1 red band x 4 (1 second pause at contraction) -> Bodyweight until you can't move an inch

Hyperextensions with Band Tension

These sets are all RPE of 8-9, last set is a 13 RPE
Goal – Supramax pump

NOTE: If you can walk normally to the car after this, go back in the gym and redo the final set.

TUESDAY

Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercises	6 sets

WEDNESDAY

Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

WEEK 3 - THURSDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*12 sets*
Biceps	2 exercises	6 sets

1/ **Back** | Supinated pulldown variation

Do a few warm up sets really focusing on feeling your lower lats squeeze hard. Today do 3 sets of 12 here. Leave a rep or two in the tank on all sets. ***3 total work sets***

Single Arm Pulldowns

These sets are all RPE of 8-9
Goal – Activation and Supramax pump

Pro Tip

If you struggle with lat contractions, unilateral movements can really increase the mind to muscle connection with the target muscle. While performing this lift, maintain an active Lat on the arm that isn't lifting by keeping your shoulder down and locked. If you notice your shoulder blade rising up toward you head, you are losing focus. Maintain a nice distance between your shoulder blade and your head.

2/ **Back** | Underhand pulldown

Back to the hammer strength machine today or a similar machine, but we are adding an intensity technique. Watch the video closely as Fouad nailed what we are after here today. See the example below just to get an idea of how the progression looks. ***3 total work sets***

2 plates per side x 10 (set 1)

3 plates per side x 10 (set 2)

3 plates and a 25 x6 -> 3 plates x 4 -> 2 plates x 8 -> 1 plate x 8 + 10 second ISO Hold (set 3)

Supinated Pulldowns with IFBB Pro's Ken Jackson and Fouad Abiad

These sets are all RPE of 8-9, the last set is a 13.
Goal – Supramax pump

3/ **Back** | Banded shrugs

Do 3 sets of 12 here with a 2 second pause at the top of each rep. ***3 total work sets***

Band shrugs

These sets are all RPE of 10.
Goal – Supramax pump

4/ **Back** | TRX horizontal chins

Fast forward to "15:06" of the attached video and watch how we do these. If you don't have a TRX, some gymnast rings work well here too. I want 3 sets to failure to finish the day off. ***3 total work sets***

Get A Wide Back With This Killer Workout

These sets are all RPE of 10
Goal – Supramax pump

Note: jot down the total number of reps you got on all 3 sets please. (foreshadowing for Week 4)

FRIDAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 3 - SATURDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*16 sets*
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

1/ **Back** | Rope straight arm pulldown

Attach a rope (or 2 if you are lucky enough to have 2 matching ropes in your gym). I want sets of 12 here really trying to drive as much blood into your lats as possible.

Superset with

2/ **Back** | Face Pulls

So you simply head back over to where you started, sit down on a box and do 10 pulls to your chest. This will put a hurting on your upper back.

Superset with

3/ **Back** | Kettlebell rows

If you do not have kettlebells, use dumbbells here. Do sets of 10 here.

Superset with

4/ **Back** | Stretchers

Duck your head and really stretch out your lats with this movement. Give me sets of 10 with this exercise. I attached a video if you all need a refresher on the form. ***4 rounds for a total of 16 work sets.***

Stretchers

These sets are all RPE of 10

SUNDAY - FAMILY DAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 4

Monday		
Back	***5 exercises***	***18 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	4 sets
	6 exercises	22 sets

Tuesday		
Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	8 exercises	27 sets

Wednesday		
Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	5 exercises	17 sets

Thursday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***15 sets***
Biceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	6 exercises	21 sets

Friday - Off

Saturday		
Back	***6 exercises***	***18 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	8 exercises	28 sets

Sunday - Off - Family Day

WEEK 4 - MONDAY

Back	*5 exercises*	*18 sets*
Abs	1 exercises	4 sets

1/ **Back** | Meadows rows

Second week in a row starting here with the meadows row. Instead of a drop set we are doing the famous challenge set to finish the movement off. See the chart for how I want things to look. ***3 total work sets***

Meadows rows - 3 different techniques

These sets are all RPE of 9-10 and 3rd set is 13
Goal – Activation and start pump

25# x 12 reps (warm up set)
35# x 12 reps (warm up set)
50# x 12 reps (warm up set)
75# x 4 reps (feeder set)
100# x 10 reps (1st work set)
110# x 10 reps (2nd work set)
125# x 21 reps on the right arm, rest 2 mins and got 20 reps with the left arm (3rd work set) – Loosen form a little on these to get extra reps.

2/ **Back** | T-bar row rest pause

Doesn't get more old school than this back thickener. Give me 4 hard sets of 8. ***4 total work sets***

Rest pause flex row - old school tbar

These sets are 9-10 RPE
Goal – Supramax pump

Pro Tip
Notice how the bar is loaded with 25's so it increases your range of motion.

3/ **Back** | Single arm cable row

After 2 brutal rowing exercises, let's go over to the cable and really isolate each lat. This should feel amazing because you get a great stretch and the contraction should be 10 out of 10. Give me 4 sets of 10 each arm here. ***4 total work sets***

Single Arm Cable Rows

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

4/ **Back** | Supported rows

I am attaching two different videos, so you can see how this would look. I want a stretch at the beginning, then drive the weight up hard. In video #1, you can see the stretch so much you will slightly come out of the seat. On video #2 (fast forward to 2:15), I know not everyone is lucky enough to have this Prime piece, but it's the same premise. Knock down 4 sets of 8 here. ***4 total work sets***

Supported Rows

or

Winter Bulk | Back Workout That Will Put On Massive Size

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

5/ **Back** | Farmer's walks

Use a yolk, or dumbells, or even those long tube things here. Take 10 steps with each leg. That is 1 set. Do 3 hard sets. Keep your spine straight! ***3 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 8
Goal – Endurance

TUESDAY

Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercises	6 sets

WEDNESDAY

Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

WEEK 4 - THURSDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*15 sets*
Biceps	2 exercises	6 sets

1/ **Back** | Supinated pulldown variation

If you have never done this before, you are in for a treat. Hook your arm into the band, have a seat and do your pulldowns. Give me 3 sets of 10 each arm here. ***3 total work sets***

One arm pulldowns with isometric contraction

These sets are all RPE of 8-9
Goal – Activation and Supramax pump

Pro Tip
Maintain constant tension on the non-working lat by trying to drive your elbow down and towards your spine.

2/ **Back** | Pulldown superset

This a power packed superset guaranteed to push the pump of your back. Do 10 reps facing away then flip right around and do 10 more. On your final set add a 10 second stretch in the fully lengthened position. Ideally you will use a shoulder width, neutral attachment.
3 rounds for 6 total work sets

Set 1: 130# x 10(facing away from the stack) then x 10 (facing the stack)

Set 2: 150# x 10(facing away from the stack) then x 10 (facing the stack)

Set 3: 170# x 10 (facing away from the stack) then 10 (facing the stack) with a forced stretch then 10 second forced stretch

Pulldown superset with Ifbb Pro Ken Jackson

These sets are all RPE of 8-9, the last set is a 13.
Goal – Supramax pump

3/ **Back** | Pullovers

These felt so great third that I left them there but removed the band. You should be able to go up in weight for your 3 sets of 10 here. ***3 total work sets***

Dumbell pullovers

These sets are all RPE of 8-9.
Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

4/ **Back** | TRX horizontal chins

Ok these are money for low lats! So, they stay in here, but we need to beat the total number of reps you got last week. Fast-forward to "15:06" of the attached video and watch how we do these. If you don't have a TRX, some gymnast rings work well here too. I want 3 sets to failure to finish the day off. ***3 total work sets***

Get A Wide Back With This Killer Workout

These sets are all RPE of 10
Goal – Supramax pump

FRIDAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 4 - SATURDAY

Back	*6 exercises*	*18 sets*
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

This week we are splitting the large giant set into 2 trisets, so you can use more weight on each exercise. Do a couple warm up rounds to get a pump and find the right load of each exercise. Rest only 2 minutes between rounds before starting again. ENJOY!!

1/ **Back** | Pronated cable row

Put 2 single d-handles on the seated cable row and let's work that mid back. I want you pulling to your upper abs and then getting a good stretch at the lengthened position. Sets of 10 should feel great here.

Pronated Cable Row

Superset with

2/ **Back** | Dumbbell rows

Drag a dumbbell over and do 10 reps each arm right off the back of the seat on the cable machine.

Superset with

3/ **Back** | Face Pulls

Finally just attach a rope to the high cable and drive your elbows towards your rib cage. These should almost cramp your back. Give me sets of 12 here. ***3 rounds for a total of 9 work sets***

Face pulls

Superset with

4/ **Back** | Neutral grip pulldowns

Standard pulldowns, pulling all the way to your upper chest for 10 reps.

Superset with

5/ **Back** | Trap bar rows

Trap bar rows – On this exercise, do not lower the bar all the way down, but I want you driving up to squeeze your lats hard with all 10 reps of each set. If you do not have a trap bar you can use dumbells with a neutral grip (palms facing in).

Trap bar rows

Superset with

6/ **Back** | Stretchers

Lets finish with stretchers as the attachment is already loaded and ready to be pulled. Sets of 10 here will feel great coming off the trap bar rows. ***3 rounds for a total of 9 work sets***

Stretchers

These sets are all RPE of 10

SUNDAY - FAMILY DAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 5

Monday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***15 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	4 sets
	5 exercises	20 sets

Tuesday		
Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	8 exercises	27 sets

Wednesday		
Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	5 exercises	17 sets

Thursday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***15 sets***
Biceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	6 exercises	21 sets

Friday - Off

Saturday		
Back	***5 exercises***	***25 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	7 exercises	35 sets

Sunday - Off - Family Day

WEEK 5 - MONDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*15 sets*
Abs	1 exercises	4 sets

1/ **Back** | One arm barbell rows

Going back to where we started exercise wise. I want a slow pyramid, meaning do not make big jumps here. I want you to keep going up in weight until you miss 8 reps. We will call this 4 sets. ***4 total work sets***

One Arm Barbell Rows

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Activation and start pump

2/ **Back** | Smith machine row rest pause

Just like with exercise 1, I want a pyramid up doing sets of 8. On your final set I want you to load more weight and do a triple dropset. The goal is to get 4 perfect form reps, drop some weight, get 4 more reps, then finally make a larger drop and do 6 more perfect reps. Notice all reps were done with a full pause at the bottom of each rep. ***4 total work sets***

Smith Machine Bent Over Rows

These sets are 9-10 RPE with the last set being a 13
Goal – Supramax pump

Pro Tip

If your Smith machine doesn't go low enough for you to get a full ROM, stand on some blocks to increase it.

3/ **Back** | T-bar rows

If you have done Program #15 (The Executioner) you will remember the high rep t-bar rows Tom Platz introduced to us. You want to get into a rhythm doing these. You are going to be doing a lot of sets and reps. You really just need to let the bar come up and down in a good tempo. The pain and pump will come. See the chart for how I want your pyramid in both reps and weights to look. ***4 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 9-13
Goal – Supramax pump

Here is the example of what to do:

1 25 lb plate x 20 reps – Warm up

1 25 lb plate x 30 reps – Warm up

2 25 lb plate x 40 reps – Set 1

3 25 lb plate x 40 reps plus 5 partner assisted forced reps – Set 2

3 25 lb plate x 40 reps plus 5 partner assisted forced reps – Set 3

4 25 lb plate x Failure – Set 4

4/ **Back** | Deficit Deadlifts

Stand on a bumper plate or a couple 45-pound plates to increase this range of motion. Do not make big jumps in weight here as this is an extremely tough exercise. Work your way up to a moderately heavy weight and give me 3 sets of 6 here. ***3 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 8
Goal – Train explosively

NOTE: This is a BRUTAL Day!

Pro Tip

If you don't want to stand on anything, use 25-pound plates on the bar.

TUESDAY

Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercises	6 sets

WEDNESDAY

Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

WEEK 5 - THURSDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*15 sets*
Biceps	2 exercises	6 sets

1/ **Back** | Shoulder width pulldowns

If you have access to a mag-grip handle I want you to use that today. I prefer the neutral grip one, but any of them will work well with what we are doing today. After a few warm up sets I want you to pyramid up in weight doing sets of 10. The catch here is drive your elbows down hard, but hold the contraction for 2 seconds, then control the negative up. Reps 1-6 may be easy, it's the last 4 where your lats will really begin to burn. Once you can no longer hold the contraction or control the negative, move onto the next exercise. ***3 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 8-9
Goal – Activation and Supramax pump

Pro Tip

With every rep think about hitting a back double bicep pose. The harder you squeeze the better this will look on stage. If you aren't a competitor, think how much tighter your super hero t-shirts will be through the back.

2/ **Back** | Chin up death

Now that you are good and warmed up, let's do pullups. I want 2 sets wide grip, 2 sets just outside of shoulder width and 2 sets narrow and neutral. Do all these sets to failure and like always, feel free to add weight to your body or bands or use the assisted machine! The goal for each set is 10 reps, so adjust your method accordingly. ***6 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 8-9.
Goal – Supramax pump

3/ **Back** | Machine pullovers

It's hard to beat the Nautilus pullover machine. If you do not have one of these or something similar (hammer strength makes a pretty good plate loaded pull over) feel free to use a dumbbell or cable straight arm pulldown. Knock down 3 sets of 10 here to really stretch out your lats. ***3 total work sets***

Nautilus Pullover

These sets are all RPE of 8-9.
Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

4/ **Back** | One arm supinated pulldowns

On these today, do 3 sets of 10 each arm. Then at the end of each set stretch both lats for 15 seconds. The idea is pump, pump, pump, then stretch them out really well. ***3 total work sets***

Supinated pulldowns with one arm

These sets are all RPE of 10
Goal – Supramax pump

FRIDAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 5 - SATURDAY

Back	*5 exercises*	*25 sets*
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

Back to 5 exercises in a row, but we are doing 5 rounds of this today! As always do a couple rounds to get warm, a lat pump and find the right weight for each exercise.

Giant sets for back

1/ **Back** | Smith machine row

I want these all done rest pause style. Give me 8 reps with perfect form.

Superset with

2/ **Back** | Dumbbell pullovers

Big arch, each set get more range of motion and do not come past your forehead. Another 8 reps here without engaging your triceps. Remember to lock your elbows in stone.

Superset with

3/ **Back** | Kettlebell row

Watch the form closely. When the kettlebells are at full extension, they are in the neutral grip. As you pull up, transition to semi-supinated to nail your lower lats. Another 8 reps here.

Superset with

4/ **Back** | Banded face pulls

Attach a long red EliteFTS band to the top of the power rack, drive your elbows back and down, pulling your hands towards your chest. The progressive resistance here will make your upper back knot up like crazy if you are standing far enough away from the rack. Give me 8 reps where you hold the contraction for all 8 reps.

Superset with

5/ **Back** | Lat hang

The last exercise is a dead hang from a pullup bar. Take a shoulder width, pronated grip and just let yourself hang for as long as you can. Shoot for 60 seconds and if you can do longer than that, simply hang weight off your waist with a dip belt to achieve the desired stretch. Use wrist straps so your grip doesn't give out too soon. ***5 rounds for a total of 25 work sets.***

These sets are all RPE of 10

SUNDAY - FAMILY DAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 6

Monday		
Back	***6 exercises***	***22 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	4 sets
	7 exercises	26 sets

Tuesday		
Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	8 exercises	27 sets

Wednesday		
Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	5 exercises	17 sets

Thursday		
Back	***4 exercises***	***18 sets***
Biceps	2 exercise	6 sets
	6 exercises	24 sets

Friday - Off

Saturday		
Back	***7 exercises***	***23 sets***
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercise	5 sets
	9 exercises	33 sets

Sunday - Off - Family Day

WEEK 6 - MONDAY

Back	*6 exercises*	*22 sets*
Abs	1 exercises	4 sets

Back: Last week, Finish STRONG!

1/ **Back** | Dumbbell rows

Final week and this one is going to be a ball buster. I want sets of 10 pyramiding up in weight till you reach a top end 10, once there we are going to do a quad drop set. See the chart for an idea of how to choose your weights. We will call this 4 sets. ***4 total work sets***

Dumbell row dropset

These sets are all RPE of 9-10 except set 4 with is 13.
Goal – Activation and start pump

40# x 10 (warm up)
60# x 10 (warm up)
80# x 10 (warm up)
100# x 10 (1st work set)
120# x 10 (2nd work set)
130# x10 (3rd work set)
140# x 10 -> 110# x 10 -> 80# x 10 -> 50# x 10 (4th work set)

2/ **Back** | One arm barbell row superset with meadows row

After that dumbbell drop set, gather yourself because there is zero let up today. We are going right into one arm barbell row for 6 reps followed immediately by Meadows rows for 6 reps. Do not rest between arms but take a nice 3-minute rest between sets. ***4 rounds for 8 total work sets***

One arm barbell row meadows row superset

These sets are 9-10 RPE
Goal – Supramax pump

Pro Tip
This is going to take some heart. Mental toughness is not often discussed when building training programs, but it is required to build an impressive physique.

3/ **Back** | Seated cable row

After 3 free weight exercises let's head over to the cable station. Elevate the seat so you are pulling from a higher angle and use 2 d-handles to get more range of motion. Check out the form as you will be going from pronated (full stretched position) to semi-supinated (in the contracted position). 4 sets of 10 will be what we need to do. ***4 total work sets***

Elevated supinated cable rows

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

4/ **Back** | Prone shrugs against rack

So to give your arms a break, but still attack your mid back, let's do some prone shrugs against the rack. This range of motion isn't big but will make you cramp like crazy when done right. Leave your arms fixed, do not row this to engage your lats or biceps. Just try to smash your low traps together as hard as possible. Watch the video a few times to get the form correct. Give me 3 sets of 10 reps. ***3 total work sets***

Prone shrugs against rack for mid back and lower traps

These sets are all RPE of 9-10
Goal – Supramax pump

5/ **Back** | Reverse hyperextension

After all the rowing this will really feel great on your back, yet continue to push your pump into your erectors, glutes and hamstrings. Give me 3 sets of 10 here. ***3 total work set.***

Reverse Hyperextension

Note: if you do not have a reverse hyper, banded or barbell good mornings are a great alternative.

Banded Good Mornings

These sets are all RPE of 8
Goal – Supramax pump

TUESDAY

Chest	3 exercises	12 sets
Shoulders	3 exercises	9 sets
Triceps	2 exercises	6 sets

WEDNESDAY

Legs	4 exercises	12 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

WEEK 6 - THURSDAY

Back	*4 exercises*	*18 sets*
Biceps	2 exercises	6 sets

NOTE: Short and sweet today. Monday was hell and as always, we are going to finish strong with a killer Saturday session.

1/ **Back** | Chin up mega death

So I want to start here with 9 total sets of pullups. Just like last week but 1 more set at each grip. So, 3 wide, 3 outside of shoulder width and 3 narrow/neutral. This will have you pumped right out of the gate. Feel free to do these banded. ***9 total work sets***

These sets are all RPE of 8-9
Goal – Activation and Supramax pump

Pro Tip
Keep your chest arched the entire time as this will maximally engage the lats.

2/ **Back** | Straight arm pulldown

Give me 3 sets of 10 here. ***3 total work sets***

Grenade straight arm pushdowns

These sets are all RPE of 8-9.
Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

3/ **Back** | One arm supinated pulldowns

On these today, do 3 sets of 10 each arm. Remember to slightly lean backwards and side bend, then drive your elbow straight down. ***3 total work sets***

Single Arm Pulldowns

These sets are all RPE of 10
Goal – Supramax pump

4/ **Back** | Machine pullovers

These felt so great last week, lets finish with the Nautilus pullover machine. If you do not have one of these or something similar (hammer strength makes a pretty good plate loaded pull over) feel free to use a dumbbell pullover. Do 3 sets of 10 here to really stretch out your lats again. ***3 total work sets***

Nautilus Pullover

These sets are all RPE of 8-9.
Goal – Train muscle from a stretched position

FRIDAY
OFF DAY

WEEK 6 - SATURDAY

Back	*7 exercises*	*23 sets*
Abs	1 exercise	5 sets
Calves	1 exercises	5 sets

The goal here is to train like a CHAMPION!! Hopefully you have some before photos and can take some after pics today to compare and see your progress.

1/ **Back** | Wide grip lat pulldown

Starting with a triset to get lots of blood in your back. You can use the wide Mag-grip like Brett is using in the video or any wide bar attachment. ***Do sets of 10 here.***

Superset with

2/ **Back** | Rope row

Set the cable system in the high setting and pull toward your hips. The goal here is lower lat. ***Sets of 10 here as well.***

Superset with

3/ **Back** | Seated cable row

Lastly attach a neutral grip that is just outside of shoulder width and do 10 reps of rows. Lean forward slightly to stretch your lats, then drive those elbows back. ***3 rounds for a total of 9 work sets.***

Tri-Set Back Workout 2 Get A V-Taper!

These sets are all RPE of 9-10.

Superset with

4/ **Back** | Banded supported row

You are going to love this exercise, attach 2 red bands to the t-bar and give me sets of 10 here.

Banded supported rows

Superset with

5/ **Back** | Dumbbell row

Go right into dumbbell rows, 10 each arm.

Superset with

6/ **Back** | Supinated pulldown

Attach 2 d-handles to the cable station, face away from the weight stack and drive your elbows straight down. Give me sets of 12 here. ***3 rounds for a total of 9 work sets.***

Supinated pull down variation

These sets are all RPE of 9-10.

Superset with

7/ **Back** | ISO hold into smith dead

With this finisher we are going to do a 10 second ISO hold with a long red EliteFTS band, then right into sets of 8 on smith machine deadlifts. Make sure you are not bouncing the weight off the rack and using your lats on every rep, not just your erectors. ***5 total work sets.***

Iso-hold into Smith Deadlift

These sets are all RPE of 10-12.

SUNDAY - FAMILY DAY
OFF DAY

THIS CONCLUDES OUR 6-WEEK BACK ATTACK!

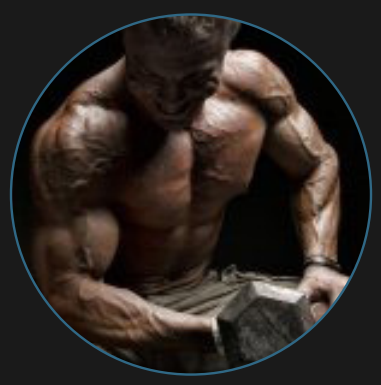
It would now be wise to pull back the frequency and go back to a 2 a day or even a 1 time every 5-day routine for back!

Thank you as always and keep cranking!

John Meadows

Make sure to follow us on Instagram

@mountaindog1



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If you are looking for full training programs visit the Mountain Dog site at:

https://mountaindogdiet.com/category/programs/

Follow John on YouTube at mountaindog1 for many more complete workouts!

If you are looking to take your knowledge of training, nutrition, and supplements to the next level, please don't hesitate to sign up on my member website at https://mountaindogdiet.com/membership/

Thank you so much for your support!

John Meadows